

# **Narcissistic Processes: Optimistic Expectations, Favorable Self-Evaluations, and Self-Enhancing Attributions**

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**ABSTRACT** Three studies investigated the relationship between narcissism (as measured by the Narcissistic Personality Inventory; Raskin & Hall, 1979) and three forms of self-enhancement. In Study 1, narcissism positively correlated with predictions of own final course grades, but not with actual grades received. In Study 2, narcissism positively correlated with estimated current course grades; high narcissists tended to overestimate their grades, while low narcissists tended to underestimate them. In Study 3, narcissism was associated with optimistic expectations for own performance on a laboratory interdependence task and with attributions of a successful task outcome to own ability and effort, but it did not correlate with attributions to a partner's ability or effort, suggesting self-aggrandizement but not other-derogation. Narcissism was also associated with weaker gratitude and liking. Results are discussed in terms of

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their implications for the origins and generality of self-enhancement and for the relationship between narcissism and self-functioning in the social domain.

In Garrison Keillor's Lake Wobegon, Minnesota, the women are strong, the men beautiful, and all the children are above average. Like the fictitious inhabitants of Lake Wobegon, many of us exhibit a general tendency to evaluate ourselves in flattering ways.

Self-enhancing beliefs may be summarized as "unrealistic, positive views of the self, exaggerated perceptions of personal control, and unrealistic optimism" (Taylor & Brown, 1988, p. 194). Persons see themselves as better than average and also judge themselves more favorably than others judge them. In addition, persons' estimates of their personal control of events are often excessive, and these beliefs may lead to unrealistic optimism. That is, when considering the future, persons tend to think they will experience more positive events than will others. Furthermore, persons are often self-enhancing in their perceptions of what caused past events, such that positive outcomes are attributed to their own ability and effort, while negative outcomes are attributed to bad luck or uncontrollable circumstances (see Taylor, 1989). Self-enhancing attributions can also occur following cooperative task performances, with individuals overestimating their own causal role in producing a collective product (see Thompson & Kelly, 1981).

Recently, individual differences in self-enhancement have been the focus of a number of investigations (see, e.g., Campbell & Fehr, 1990; Gabriel, Critelli, & Ee, 1994; John & Robins, 1994; Raskin, Novacek, & Hogan, 1991). One personality variable that has been found to correlate with the strength of such tendencies is an individual's level of narcissism. In clinical literature (e.g., Kernberg, 1975; Kohut, 1971; Millon, 1981), unrealistic, positive self-beliefs are typically included in descriptions of narcissism. Furthermore, grandiosity is listed in the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual* (DSM IV; American Psychiatric Association, 1994) as one of multiple diagnostic criteria for narcissistic personality disorder.

The grandiosity characteristic of narcissistic disorder is also observed among relatively narcissistic persons in nonclinical populations (see Raskin & Novacek, 1989). The measure most commonly used to assess this nonclinical or *dispositional* narcissism is the Narcissistic Personality Inventory (NPI) developed by Raskin and Hall (1979). NPI items were based on DSM-III (American Psychiatric Association, 1980) diagnostic criteria for narcissistic personality disorder. Factor analyses of the NPI

indicate that it measures at least four different aspects of narcissism, namely, leadership/authority, superiority/arrogance, self-absorption/self-admiration, and exploitiveness/entitlement (Emmons, 1984, 1987). However, more recent evidence indicates additional NPI components, namely, vanity, exhibitionism, and self-sufficiency (Raskin & Terry, 1988).

As mentioned, dispositional narcissism is associated with tendencies to self-aggrandize. For example, Raskin et al. (1991) reported that NPI scores correlated with observer ratings of condescension and conceit, as well as with responses to the Grandiosity Scale (Watson & Klett, 1972). This scale is comprised of Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory (MMPI) items such as "I have often found people jealous of my good ideas just because they had not thought of them first."

Given that grandiosity is associated with NPI-assessed narcissism, it is not surprising that scores on the test are correlated with certain of the self-enhancing tendencies described previously. For example, Gabriel et al. (1994) compared subjects' percentile self-ratings of intelligence with their actual percentile scores on an intelligence test. In addition, subjects' percentile self-ratings of their attractiveness were compared with observer-generated percentiles. For both attributes, NPI scores were related to excessively favorable self-evaluations.

NPI-assessed narcissism has also been found to correlate with overly positive evaluations of one's own performance. In a study conducted by John and Robins (1994), master of business administration (MBA) students participated in a simulated managerial committee meeting. Students' self-evaluations were subsequently compared with evaluations given by trained observers. Self-evaluations of highly narcissistic participants were found to be most unrealistically positive.

Overall, then, narcissism appears to be systematically associated with certain forms of self-enhancement. Viewed within the context of narcissistic grandiosity, such self-enhancement may take on a somewhat negative cast. However, some researchers have argued that favorable self-beliefs are not maladaptive, but instead may contribute to psychological health and personal productivity. For example, it has been suggested that optimism concerning the future may encourage persons to take on difficult tasks, and that self-protective attributions may foster persistence in the face of failure (see Taylor, 1989). If this is true, then strong tendencies to self-enhance may be an adaptive feature of narcissism in nonclinical populations.

In order to determine whether the self-enhancement of high narcissists is adaptive, it is first necessary to identify which of the multiple forms of self-enhancement are associated with narcissism. The present three studies begin to address this question and also extend previous work on self-enhancement and narcissism in several other ways. That is, the studies focused on two types of self-enhancement not previously explored in the narcissism literature, namely, optimistic expectations for the future and self-enhancing attributions for past events. In addition, the impact of narcissism on self-functioning was assessed; we measured both expectations and subsequent performance quality to determine whether narcissism would relate to both greater optimism and better outcomes. Finally, the present research investigated whether certain forms of self-evaluations are more subject to narcissistic self-enhancement than others. In the present case, students evaluated their own performances in their classes. This enabled us to obtain two types of self-evaluations: students' estimates of their current course grades (e.g., 2.5 on a 4.0 scale) and students' estimates of their rankings in their classes (percentiles). Previous studies of narcissism and self-enhancement have obtained percentile ratings or self-rankings only (Gabriel et al., 1994; John & Robins, 1994; but see Raskin et al., 1991). In the present research we wanted to include a more absolute form of self-evaluations (i.e., grades) to determine whether the strongly social nature of percentile self-ratings intensifies high narcissists' tendencies toward self-enhancement.

## **Study 1**

### **METHOD**

#### **Subjects**

One hundred fifty-two (99 female, 53 male) undergraduate psychology students participated for extra course credit.

#### **Materials and Procedure**

During the first week of the academic quarter, subjects completed the NPI and then answered a brief questionnaire following their participation in an unrelated study. On the NPI, respondents make 40 forced choices between statements that differ in their narcissistic content (e.g., "I insist on getting the respect that is due me" vs. "I usually get the respect I deserve"). On the brief questionnaire, subjects responded to several filler questions and predicted their final grades in their

current psychology classes. Subjects were asked to report their student I.D. numbers and were guaranteed that their responses would remain anonymous. Subjects were also given the option of writing “pass” in lieu of their numbers if they preferred not to disclose them. The materials were administered in classroom settings with varying numbers of other subjects present.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Complete data were obtained from 134 (88%) of the subjects. The mean NPI score for this sample was slightly higher ( $M = 16.80$ ) than that reported by Raskin (personal communication) for college samples ( $M = 15.55$ ). Although the mean narcissism score was significantly higher for male ( $M = 19.31$ ) than for female ( $M = 15.53$ ) subjects,  $t(132) = 2.93$ ,  $p < .01$ , gender was not associated with the variable of interest, namely, subjects’ predicted grades.

As expected, subjects scoring higher on the NPI predicted better final grades relative to those scoring lower,  $r(132) = .22$ ,  $p < .01$  (one-tailed test). Furthermore, scores on five of seven NPI subscales correlated significantly with predicted grades (see Table 1). Note that exhibitionism and vanity did not significantly correlate with predicted grades. These results are not entirely surprising because these two subscales focus on attention seeking and physical self-admiration rather than beliefs about own competence and superiority.

At the end of the academic quarter, we were able to ascertain the actual final grades of 97 of the 134 subjects. Only a minority (23%) underestimated

**Table 1**  
Correlations Between NPI Subscales and Predicted Course Grades

| Subscale         | Grade |
|------------------|-------|
| Authority        | .21*  |
| Exhibitionism    | -.02  |
| Superiority      | .19*  |
| Entitlement      | .17*  |
| Exploiteness     | .18*  |
| Self-sufficiency | .18*  |
| Vanity           | .11   |

$N = 134$ .

\* =  $p < .05$ , one-tailed tests.

their grades; the mean prediction was .48 grade points higher than the actual grade received (on a 4.0-point scale). Within this group of subjects, too, narcissism correlated positively with the final grades predicted,  $r(95) = .20$ ,  $p < .05$  (one-tailed test), but *not* with the actual grades obtained,  $r(95) = -.04$ , *ns*. Thus, among this relatively optimistic sample, high narcissists were the more optimistic persons, yet high narcissists did not perform any better than less narcissistic persons. These results contrast with the suggestion that optimism for the future may increase productivity. In the present case, the positive self-beliefs exhibited by high narcissists did not confer any advantage in terms of the outcomes they actually received.

The above correlations may have been weakened by low variability in the predicted grade variable. Of the 97 subjects, only one predicted a final grade below a “B” (specifically, a “B–”). This homogeneity may have been due to selection factors—Study 1 participants were self-selected ambitious students seeking extra credit during the first week of class. In fact, the mean grade point average (GPA) for students participating in the study was slightly higher ( $M = 3.15$ ) than the overall mean for the psychology classes from which the sample was obtained ( $M = 2.90$ ). Furthermore, given a distant outcome such as a final grade, it is likely that most persons adopt a sanguine outlook, thus diminishing any individual differences in optimism. Given a more immediate outcome, however, persons may vary more in their self-predictions (see Gilovich, Kerr, & Husted Medvec, 1993).

## Study 2

Study 2 was conducted to determine the relationship between narcissism and beliefs about more proximal outcomes, that is, persons’ evaluations of their own current performances. During the last 2 weeks of the academic quarter, subjects were asked to estimate their current grades. It was expected that relatively high narcissists would also be more favorable in their more immediate self-assessments.

## METHOD

### Subjects

One hundred sixty-two (98 female, 64 male) students participated.

## Materials and Procedure

During the eighth and ninth weeks of the academic quarter, subjects completed a questionnaire at the end of a meeting of their introductory psychology classes. Subjects estimated their current grades and estimated the percent of their fellow classmates who were currently receiving grades lower than their own, then responded to several filler questions and to an eight-item “mini”-NPI (the full NPI was not used because of time limitations).

To create the mini-NPI, two item-pairs were selected from each of the four factors (e.g., Leadership/Authority) identified by Emmons (1987). These four factors were selected rather than the seven factors identified by Raskin and Terry (1988) in the interest of brevity, and also because at the time of the study there was more validating information available on the four factors (see Raskin & Terry, 1988). The selected item-pairs were those two that loaded most strongly on each factor. On the mini-NPI, only the narcissistic item from each pair was presented (e.g., “I see myself as a good leader”). Subjects responded to each of the eight items using an 11-point scale with *not at all true of me* and *extremely true of me* as the anchors.

Subjects were assured of their anonymity, were asked for their student I.D. numbers, and were invited to write “pass” if they preferred not to disclose this information.

## RESULTS

Of the 162 subjects who participated, 138 (85%) completed the mini-NPI and grade prediction scales. The alpha coefficient for the mini-NPI was .81. In addition, 38 of the 138 participants were identified as having taken the full NPI during the first week of class (i.e., they had participated in Study 1). The uncorrected for attenuation (unreliability of measures) correlation between scores on the full NPI and the mini-NPI was .58. We assume, therefore, that the mini-NPI is an adequate substitute measure for the full NPI. For the following analyses, subjects’ narcissism scores are based on the mini-NPI.

Although males scored significantly higher on the mini-NPI ( $M = 55.96$ ) than did females ( $M = 48.85$ ),  $t(136) = 3.87$ ,  $p < .001$ , gender was not consistently associated with the variables of interest. That is, males did not estimate higher current grades than did females ( $M_s = 3.32$  and  $3.15$ , respectively),  $t(136) = 1.43$ , *ns*. Males’ estimates of the percent of others scoring lower than the self were higher than females’ ( $M_s = 53.80$  and  $44.64$ , respectively),  $t(136) = 1.99$ ,  $p < .05$ . Males did not receive

higher course grades than did females ( $M_s = 3.18$  and  $3.24$ , respectively),  $t(95) < 1.00$ .

As expected, significant correlations were observed between narcissism and estimated current grades,  $r(136) = .28$ ,  $p < .001$ , and between narcissism and estimated percent of others with grades lower than one's own,  $r(136) = .37$ ,  $p < .001$  (one-tailed tests).

Forty-one subjects (25% of the original sample) did not report their student I.D. numbers, leaving 97 subjects for the following analyses. Again, the mean GPA for participating students ( $M = 3.22$ ) was slightly higher than that for the psychology classes as a whole ( $M = 2.90$ ); it should be noted that the latter group also contained those less diligent students who were not attending class on the day of the study.

Also within the above subgroup of 97 participants, significant correlations were observed between narcissism and estimated current grades,  $r(95) = .34$ ,  $p < .001$ , and between narcissism and estimated percent of others with grades lower than one's own,  $r(95) = .34$ ,  $p < .001$  (one-tailed tests). Recall that gender was also related to estimated percent of others with grades lower than one's own such that males' self-estimates were higher than females'. Furthermore, gender and narcissism were linked; males scored higher than females on the NPI. In light of these relationships, a regression analysis was performed to determine whether narcissism was related to estimated percent lower than self, controlling for any effects of gender. Results revealed a significant relationship between narcissism and estimated percent of others lower than self apart from the effects of gender,  $\beta = .838$ ,  $t = 4.11$ ,  $p < .001$ .

An unexpected, significant correlation was observed between narcissism and the actual final grade subjects received,  $r(95) = .20$ ,  $p < .05$ . Because of this significant relationship, we calculated the partial correlations between narcissism and estimated grades and between narcissism and estimated percent lower than the self, holding actual grade constant. These partial correlations were also significant,  $r_s = .32$  and  $.28$ , respectively,  $p_s < .01$ .

The above correlations do not reveal whether relatively high narcissists were overestimating their grades. To investigate this aspect of their self-reports, a tripartite split of subjects' NPI scores (i.e., into the lowest, middle, and highest one third) was performed and subjects were thus categorized as low, medium, or high narcissists. A difference score was then created between subjects' estimated current grades and the final grades they received in their classes. On a 4.0-point scale, low narcissists'



estimates were an average of .09 grade points *below* those actually received, moderate narcissists' an average of .08 points *above* those actually received, and high narcissists' an average of .12 points *above* those actually received.

## DISCUSSION

In summary, relatively narcissistic persons were more positive in their assessments of their current performances than less narcissistic persons. This association held not only for comparative (percentile) judgments, but also for more absolute (estimated grade) judgments. With regard to grade estimates, the self-evaluations of high narcissists appear to have been excessively favorable whereas those of low narcissists appear to have been somewhat pessimistic (see John & Robins, 1994, for similar findings).

Collectively, the results of Studies 1 and 2 indicate that dispositional narcissism is related to two self-enhancement processes, namely, optimistic expectations for the future and positive self-evaluations (see Taylor, 1989). In Study 1, narcissism was unrelated to performance quality. In Study 2, high narcissists did receive higher objective grades, yet they also overestimated these grades. These results support the contention that high narcissists' self-beliefs tend to be unrealistic (see Gabriel et al., 1994; John & Robins, 1994; Raskin et al., 1991).

In fact, it could be argued that the self-enhancement characteristic of high narcissists might be detrimental, insofar as it leads to disappointment when outcomes are not as favorable as expected. However, note that by the end of the academic quarter, the difference between estimated and actual grades was small (.12 grade points for high narcissists). It seems unlikely that such a small discrepancy would be greatly disturbing.

The findings of Studies 1 and 2 were informative because they show that dispositional narcissism is associated with self-enhancing beliefs about outcomes that were real and consequential for the participants. In the study that follows, we wanted to replicate and extend the preceding findings by investigating whether narcissism is also related to self-enhancing attributions for one's own performance in an interpersonal setting, namely, an achievement task performed collectively with an interdependent other. An association between narcissism and such attributional tendencies would suggest a possible mechanism that contributes to the favorable self-views of narcissistic persons.

### Study 3

The following study explored the relationships between narcissism and optimistic expectations and self-enhancing attributions for collective task performances. In addition, the study investigated whether relatively high narcissists would tend to devalue the contributions of another.

Subjects performed a creativity task independently, were told that their performance was combined with that of an unseen “partner,” and then received bogus success feedback. It was predicted that prior to completing the task, high narcissists would expect better individual and collective task performances than would low narcissists, but would not expect better or worse partner performances than low narcissists. These predictions were based on the assumption that high narcissism is primarily a self-aggrandizing rather than an other-derogating orientation (see Raskin & Terry, 1988).

Regarding persons’ causal explanations for their successful performances, narcissism was not expected to correlate with the strength of attributions to external factors (e.g., luck, task ease) because these attributions are likely to be used in the case of a negative outcome. Narcissism was expected to correlate with the strength of attributions to the internal factors of effort and ability because both these attributions are relevant to the enhancement of self-esteem (Weiner, 1986). In contrast, narcissism was not expected to correlate with attributions of the outcome to the partner’s ability and effort. Furthermore, because of their strong attributions to self, relatively high narcissists were expected to report stronger self-related positive affect (e.g., pride) and weaker other-related positive affect (e.g., gratitude) (see Kelley, 1979) in comparison to less narcissistic persons.

## METHOD

### Subjects

Participants were 67 (37 female, 30 male) undergraduate students enrolled in introductory psychology classes. Extra course credit was given for participation.

### Materials

The Unique Associates Test (UAT) is a face-valid yet bogus measure of creativity designed specifically for the present study. The UAT is described in rather ambiguous terms and requires subjects to give a single, unique word associate for each of 21 nouns. Examples are given of both typical and unique associates.

For instance, typical associates for the word “car” are “drive” or “wheels.” Unique associates are “map” and “park.”

Several self-report measures were also administered. Prior to completing the UAT, each subject responded to a questionnaire that assessed expectations for their own individual performance, their partner’s individual performance, the importance they placed on doing well on the task, and the value they placed on creativity. Subjects also indicated how well they thought they would like their partner if they were to meet him/her. Subjects responded to these questions by means of 11-point scales. In addition, subjects predicted their collective performance with their partners by estimating the percent of other “2-person groups” who would score lower than their own.

Following task performance and success feedback, subjects responded to an affect questionnaire. Using 11-point scales, subjects indicated the extent to which they were experiencing three positive, personal affects (happy, proud, competent) and two positive, interpersonal affects (liking, gratitude) (see Kelley, 1979). The above five questions were embedded among seven other filler affects. Subjects also completed an attribution questionnaire. Using 11-point scales, subjects indicated the extent to which luck, task ease, their own creative ability, their own effort, their partner’s creative ability, and their partner’s effort contributed to their collective performance.

Finally, to assess dispositional narcissism, the NPI (Raskin & Hall, 1979) was administered.

### Procedure

Subjects completed a “biographical questionnaire” in their psychology classes a few days prior to the study. They were asked for their name, age, gender, political party, favorite TV show, and favorite color. They were told that this information would be used to match them with a partner in a study about group problem solving. In reality, no such matching was done. Subjects indicated the day and time they would like to participate in the study and were contacted by telephone to confirm their appointments.

When subjects arrived at the laboratory, they were directed to one of six small rooms surrounding a central area. They silently read instructions as the experimenter also read them aloud. Subjects were given a bogus story about a newly developed creativity test entitled the Unique Associates Test (UAT). They were informed that their score on this test would be combined with that of a partner who was either similar or dissimilar to them in terms of several important attitudes and values as measured by the biographical questionnaire.<sup>1</sup>

1. A manipulation check revealed that this manipulation of partner similarity was not effective. In addition, this variable did not influence any of the findings reported here, and so it is not discussed further.

All subjects were told that they had been assigned the subject number "24" and that their partner was "103," and then received the UAT instructions after which they completed a comprehension check. Subjects were then given bogus information about their assigned partner regarding his/her similarity. Subsequently, they predicted how successful they and their partner would be on the creativity test. The UAT was distributed and 8 minutes were allotted for its completion. As the UATs were collected, subjects were told that the test would take about 20 minutes to score and were asked to respond to a series of self-perception measures that included the NPI followed by three measures that were not used in the present study. Subjects were told that the measures were for a different experimenter and study.

After 20 minutes, all subjects received written success feedback. They were told "You have done very well on this task. Your composite score with your partner is better than 85% of all other groups and individuals on this test. Your score and your partner's score were significantly different from one another." Subjects were given this discrepancy information to avoid socially desirable responses in which subjects might simply credit themselves and their partner equally.

Finally, subjects were asked to write down what they believed the study was about. At the conclusion of the experimental session, they were debriefed and the deception was explained.

## RESULTS

Data from 11 subjects (16%) were not analyzed because they either expressed suspicions regarding the procedure or failed to complete the NPI. That left 56 subjects for the following analyses. The mean narcissism score for this sample ( $M = 16.21$ ) was similar to that reported for college samples ( $M = 15.55$ ). Because there were no systematic effects of gender on the variables of interest, it is not discussed further. Finally, unless otherwise noted, the following significance levels are based on one-tailed tests.

Results of the study are summarized in Table 2. The first two hypotheses tested were that narcissism would be related to predictions of one's own performance, but would not be related to predictions of one's partner's performance. Consistent with the first hypothesis, a significant correlation was obtained between narcissism and predictions of own performance,  $r(54) = .33, p < .01$ . In addition, an unexpected, significant correlation between narcissism and predictions of partner's performance was observed,  $r(54) = -.25, p < .05$ . In contrast to predictions of their own individual performances, relatively high narcissists did not predict

**Table 2**  
Narcissism, Pretask Predictions, Posttask Attributions,  
and Posttask Affect

| Type of response        | Narcissism |
|-------------------------|------------|
| Pretask predictions     |            |
| Own performance         | .33**      |
| Partner's performance   | -.25*      |
| Collective performance  | -.01       |
| Posttask attributions   |            |
| Luck                    | -.13       |
| East of task            | .04        |
| Own ability             | .32**      |
| Own effort              | .33**      |
| Partner's ability       | -.14       |
| Partner's effort        | -.10       |
| Posttask affect         |            |
| Positive, personal      | .16        |
| Positive, interpersonal | -.23*      |

\* =  $p < .05$ .

\*\* =  $p < .01$ , one-tailed tests.

better collective performances than did less narcissistic persons,  $r(54) = -.01$ , *ns*.

As expected, narcissism was not correlated with the extent to which persons attributed their successful performances to the more external factors of luck and task ease ( $r_s = -.13$  and  $.04$ , respectively, *ns*). However, significant correlations were obtained between narcissism and attributions to own ability,  $r(54) = .32$ ,  $p < .01$ , and own effort,  $r(54) = .33$ ,  $p < .01$ . Also as expected, narcissism was not correlated with attributions of the success to partner's ability or effort ( $r_s = -.14$  and  $-.10$  respectively, both *ns*).

The expected positive correlation between narcissism and positive, personal affect was not significant,  $r(54) = .16$ ,  $p < .15$ . A significant inverse correlation between narcissism and positive, interpersonal affect was obtained,  $r(54) = -.23$ ,  $p < .05$ .

## DISCUSSION

In keeping with the results of Study 1, in Study 3 a relationship was found between dispositional narcissism and optimism about one's own future

performance. These results were not due to stronger task motivation on the part of high narcissists, as they did not report placing greater value on creativity or importance on the task relative to low narcissists ( $r_s = .07$  and  $.13$ , *ns*). Interestingly, although relatively high narcissists expected better individual performances than did less narcissistic persons, they did not predict better collective performances. These results suggest that the optimism characteristic of high narcissists does not readily extend to others who are associated with the self.

An unexpected, negative correlation was obtained between narcissism and predictions of the partner's performance. Given that envy is a component of narcissism (see Kernberg, 1975), it is possible that high narcissists held more negative views of their partner's competence because they felt competitive with them. However, we are reluctant to imbue these findings with any more significance as they were not anticipated and are not consistent with the attribution data also obtained here.

Subjects' postfeedback attributions were consistent with their pretask expectations for their own performances. That is, high narcissists attributed success more to own ability and effort than did less narcissistic persons. Narcissism was not related to the degree to which persons attributed success to their partners. This latter finding supports the contention that narcissism is primarily a self-aggrandizing rather than an other-derogating orientation.

The above attribution findings are important because they imply a process by which high narcissists maintain their positive views of self, even in the absence of superior performances. Although relatively high narcissists did not receive better outcomes in Study 3 (or in Study 1 for that matter), they did make stronger internal attributions for positive outcomes than did less narcissistic persons. Furthermore, in Study 3, attributions to own effort and ability were positively correlated with feelings of competence ( $r_s = .24$  and  $.36$ , respectively,  $p_s < .05$  and  $.01$ , one-tailed tests). Collectively, these results suggest that positive events can have a stronger impact on the self-esteem of high relative to low narcissists because these individuals perceive themselves as being more causal in producing them. It is likely that high narcissists' attributional tendencies both reflect and maintain the positive self-regard that characterizes these persons.

Despite their stronger attributions of the success to self, high narcissists did not report stronger positive, personal affect. The absence of a connection between narcissism and event-related positive affect has been

reported previously (see Kernis & Sun, 1994). Furthermore, an inability to derive pleasure from achievement is characteristic of those with narcissistic personality disorder (DSM III-R; American Psychiatric Association, 1987). It is possible that the higher self-expectations of narcissistic persons diminish the pleasure they obtain from their own accomplishments, perhaps because they do not seem out of the ordinary. This interpretation awaits further investigation.

Finally, relatively high narcissists did not devalue the contributions of their partners, yet they did report less positive, interpersonal affect (e.g., gratitude) toward their partners than did less narcissistic persons. These findings were not simply due to a more negative interpersonal orientation on the part of high narcissists. Prior to completing the creativity task, narcissism was unrelated to subjects' expected liking for their partners  $r(54) = .08, ns$ .

It is possible that high narcissists' relatively weak positive, interpersonal affect may derive from their tendencies to focus on their own contributions to a successful, collective product. To determine whether the narcissism-interpersonal affect relationship was mediated by attributions to self, we calculated the partial correlation between narcissism and interpersonal affect, controlling for the effect of these attributions. This procedure left the inverse relationship virtually unchanged ( $r = -.24$ ), suggesting that some aspect(s) of narcissism (e.g., self-absorption) leads to self-oriented attributions and weaker gratitude/liking.

The present findings are consistent with previous observations of an association between narcissism and difficulties in close relationships (see, e.g., Wink, 1991). It may be that tendencies to focus on own contributions and weaker positive, interpersonal affect contribute to such relationship distress (see Bradbury & Fincham, 1990). The attributions and affect of high and low narcissists within close relationships is an interesting area for further exploration.

In conclusion, it should be acknowledged that Study 3 was limited because it did not address persons' attributions for negative events. It is important to investigate whether narcissism is also related to rejection of blame for undesirable outcomes, but we expect that a pattern of results complementary to the present findings are likely to obtain. That is, it is probable that high narcissists would attribute less blame to the self than would low narcissists because such events are inconsistent with their relatively positive self-concepts. Furthermore, if high narcissists attribute negative events to others, they may tend to experience more anger relative

to low narcissists. Elevated levels of anger (McCann & Biaggio, 1989) and hostility (Raskin & Novacek, 1989) have in fact been associated with higher levels of narcissism (see also Kernis & Sun, 1994).

### **GENERAL DISCUSSION**

Results of the present and past studies reveal that narcissism is associated with several self-enhancing beliefs of interest to social psychologists. In the present case, narcissism correlated with optimistic expectations, positive assessments of current performance, and self-enhancing attributions for a past event. Although these correlations were modest in size, their pattern was consistent across studies and they are entirely compatible with the nature of narcissism. That is, if inflated self-esteem characterizes the self, it is likely that it will also color the future one anticipates, the present one perceives, and the past one accounts for.

The systematic nature of these findings implies that a seemingly diverse array of positive biases may be influenced by dispositional narcissism. Furthermore, situational factors may interact with narcissism to affect the expression of such biases. If this is determined to be true, then it would add substantially to our understanding of how and why self-enhancing processes occur. To begin addressing this possibility, the relationship between narcissism and other forms of self-enhancement should be explored. For example, narcissism may also be correlated with tendencies to develop illusions of personal control or to show positive distortions in memory.

The present findings also raise questions concerning the degree to which self-enhancement is characteristic of most persons. For example, in Study 2, low narcissists actually exhibited self-diminishment by underestimating their grades. These findings suggest that the overall self-enhancement documented previously may have been due to the responses of a subset of relatively narcissistic persons (for a discussion of this issue, see John & Robins, 1994). However, note that the strength of self-enhancement appeared to vary between Studies 1 and 2, as did the correlations between narcissism and self-enhancement. Recall that Study 1 was conducted during the first week of class before students had received any evaluative feedback. Given a distant outcome and unbridled by reality, persons were fairly optimistic, and the differences due to variations in narcissism were small. Study 2 was conducted at the end of the quarter; grade estimates were less favorable and more variable, and



their accuracy was greater. In this case, narcissism was more strongly related to estimated grades. These differences in results lead us to speculate that the relationship between narcissism and self-enhancement may depend on context. As suggested previously, contextual factors may interact with narcissism; in some cases, only high narcissists may self-enhance, in others, more general self-enhancement may obtain.

In addition to their relevance to the issue of self-enhancement, the present studies also speak to the nature of high dispositional narcissism and to its possible consequences. Only in Study 2 was the optimism of high narcissists related to more positive outcomes. Although high narcissists in Study 2 overestimated their grades, it is important to keep in mind that the actual discrepancies between beliefs and outcomes were quite small. This relative accuracy was likely due to the fact that the outcomes to be predicted were specific and objective evidence was available (Felson, 1981). The findings of Study 2 indicate that subjects were attending to objective information, and though high narcissists' self-beliefs were relatively positive, they were not of the "grandiose" type associated with narcissistic pathology.

Small discrepancies such as those observed here appear benign, and are consistent with a positive view of high levels of dispositional narcissism. However, whether positive self-beliefs are adaptive depends not only on their strength (i.e., how "realistic" they are), but also on the context within which they occur. In the interpersonal context of Study 3, high narcissists did not overtly devalue their partners' contributions, yet along with their stronger attributions of success to themselves they expressed less positive affect toward their partners. The attribution and affect data documented here raise questions about how narcissism influences the quality of interpersonal relationships.

In conclusion we would like to argue that it is important to explore further the social consequences of variations in dispositional narcissism. As measured by the NPI, narcissism is a reliable and multifaceted construct with numerous social implications. That is, it is largely defined in terms of persons' interpersonal thoughts (e.g., positive social comparisons) and interpersonal behaviors (e.g., manipulateness). It is likely that a number of the processes described in social psychological literature (e.g., conformity, competition) vary systematically with narcissism. The impact of narcissism on multiple social processes is an important topic for future investigation.

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